MAP HISTORIAN INDEPENDENT STUDY PROGRAM

Hereford Mappa Mundi (c. 1300) — Activity Cards

Choose any tier, in any order • Each card blends story, tasks, and reflection

🟢 EASY TIER — "First Light"

📖 The Story

The Hereford Mappa Mundi stops visitors cold — not because it is accurate, but because it is so completely, unapologetically itself. Oriented with East at the top (hence our word 'orientation'), Jerusalem sits at the literal center, Eden crowns the apex, and Britain clings humbly to the lower-left edge. This is not a map of where things are. It is a map of what things mean.

✅ Study Checklist

- ☐ Find a high-resolution image (Hereford Cathedral's website has an excellent zoomable version)
- ☐ Locate Jerusalem at the center — note how everything radiates outward from it
- ☐ Find the Garden of Eden at the very top — note how it is depicted (circular walled enclosure)
- ☐ Identify Britain and Ireland at the lower left edge — note their size relative to the Holy Land
- ☐ Find the figure of Christ at the apex of the map, presiding in judgment
- ☐ Read a short overview of what a 'Mappa Mundi' means and why medieval maps faced East

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. This map places Jerusalem at the center — a theological, not geographical, choice. What do you place at the center of your own mental map of the world? What does that say about your values?

2. The map was hung in a cathedral, not a library. It was meant to be experienced, not used. What is the difference between information designed to be used vs. felt? Where do you encounter that distinction today?

🟡 MEDIUM TIER — "Reading the Margins"

📖 The Story

The edges of the Hereford Mappa Mundi are where it becomes truly extraordinary. Medieval cartographers believed the further you traveled from Jerusalem, the more monstrous the world became. So the margins teem with Blemmyae (faces in their chests), Sciapods (one-legged beings who use their enormous foot as a parasol), and Cynocephali (dog-headed men). Richard wasn't inventing monsters — he was being scholarly, drawing on Pliny, Solinus, and Isidore of Seville.

✅ Study Checklist

☐ Identify and name at least four ‘monstrous races’ on the map’s edges — research the ancient sources each came from

☐ Find the Tower of Babel and read about its Biblical significance

☐ Locate depictions of Alexander the Great’s legendary journeys — note how a historical figure becomes mythologized

☐ Find Noah’s Ark — note where it sits geographically and why

☐ Research Isidore of Seville’s Etymologiae and its role in transmitting classical knowledge to medieval Europe

☐ Locate the Nile River — compare its path on the map to actual geography and note what the distortion reveals

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. The monster-filled margins were drawn from respected ancient sources — not imagination. When has an authority you trusted turned out to be wrong? How did you reckon with that?

2. The map encodes the belief that strangeness increases with distance from the familiar center. Is that instinct entirely gone from the modern world — or does it still shape how we perceive distant places and peoples?

🔴 DIFFICULT TIER — “The Theology of Geography”

📖 The Story

To go deep into the Mappa Mundi you must temporarily think like a medieval Christian scholar. Richard built his map on the T-O structure — the circular world divided into Asia (top), Europe (lower left), Africa (lower right) — corresponding to Noah’s three sons. Geography was genealogy. The map is simultaneously a world map, a family tree, and a salvation narrative. And at the bottom, Richard asked viewers to pray for him — this map was his bid for posthumous intercession.

✅ Study Checklist

☐ Research the T-O map tradition — trace its origins from Isidore of Seville back through classical antiquity

☐ Identify the three continents and map them onto the Noah/sons framework (Shem/Asia, Ham/Africa, Japheth/Europe)

☐ Read Richard of Haldingham’s inscription — research what is known about his life at Lincoln and Hereford cathedrals

☐ Investigate the Augustinian framework of history embedded in the map: Creation → Fall → Redemption → Judgment

☐ Compare the Hereford Mappa Mundi to the Ebstorf Map (destroyed 1943, known from reproductions)

☐ Research the 1988 near-sale of the Mappa Mundi — Hereford Cathedral almost sold it; the public outcry that saved it is a fascinating modern coda

☐ Optional deep dive: Read excerpts from Evelyn Edson’s Mapping Time and Space: How Medieval Mapmakers Viewed Their World

✍️ Journal Prompts

1. Richard embedded a complete theology of history — Creation, Fall, Redemption, Judgment — into geography. As someone on a faith journey, what does it mean to you that someone tried to map their faith? What would your own theological map look like?

2. The map was nearly sold in 1988. A medieval object of profound spiritual significance almost became a commodity. What does that near-miss say about how societies assign value to sacred objects over time?

3. Richard asked viewers to pray for him — his map was, in part, a prayer. What would you want your own great life's work to say about you when you are gone?

🤖 Copy-Paste Prompt — Deep Dive Explorer

Paste the prompt below directly into a new Claude conversation to go deeper on this map's Difficult Tier themes:

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You are a medieval scholar and theologian steeped in the tradition of Isidore of
Seville, Augustine of Hippo, and Pliny the Elder. I want to understand the
Hereford Mappa Mundi (c. 1300) from the inside — not as a flawed geographical
document, but as a complete and coherent worldview. Walk me through the map as
if you are Richard of Haldingham explaining your own creation: (1) Explain the
theological logic behind every major structural decision — why East is up, why
Jerusalem is the center, why Eden crowns the top, why Christ presides at the
apex, and why the monstrous races inhabit the margins. (2) Explain the T-O
structure and how the three continents encode the story of Noah's sons — showing
me how geography, genealogy, and salvation history are one unified narrative.
(3) Then step outside that medieval worldview and help me understand: what does
the Hereford Mappa Mundi reveal about how any culture — medieval or modern —
encodes its deepest values and fears into the maps it makes of the world? Treat
me as a thoughtful student interested in both the historical detail and the
larger philosophical implications.
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